

Print Content

Before You Read

This guide covers the basics most first-timers ask about. It's general guidance, not a rulebook — when something matters (fares, hours, services), check the latest official source. Japan is welcoming and easy to navigate once you know a few patterns.

1. Getting Around (Trains, Subways, IC Cards)

Q: How do most travelers get around?

Trains and subways do the heavy lifting in and between cities. They're punctual, frequent, and clean. For longer distances, fast intercity trains connect major regions.

Q: What is an IC card and do I need one?

An IC card is a rechargeable contactless transit card. You tap it at the gate to ride trains, subways, and many buses, and you can also use it at convenience stores and vending machines. It saves you from buying a ticket every ride. Physical and phone-based (mobile wallet) versions exist depending on your device.

Q: How do I use a train gate?

Tap your IC card on the reader when you enter and again when you exit; the fare is deducted automatically. With a paper ticket, insert it and take it back on the other side.

Q: Should I get a rail pass?

A rail pass can be worth it if you're covering long distances between regions, and less useful for a single-city stay. Compare your planned routes against the pass price before buying — check the latest terms, as rules and pricing change.

Q: Any train etiquette I should know?

- Keep phone calls off and ringers silent.
- Don't eat on short commuter trains (long-distance trains are fine).
- Line up on the marked spots on the platform and let people off first.
- Keep backpacks off your back in crowds; put them at your feet or on the rack.
- Priority seats are for those who need them.

Q: What about taxis?

Available but pricier than transit. Doors are often automatic — don't open or close them yourself. Many accept cards and IC cards.

2. Money (Cash, Cards, ATMs)

Q: Is Japan cash-only?

Less than it used to be. Cards and contactless are widely accepted in cities, but cash is still useful for small shops, some restaurants, local transit, temples/shrines, and rural areas. Carry some cash as a backup.

Q: Where do I get cash?

ATMs at convenience stores and post offices commonly accept foreign cards. Tell your bank you're traveling so your card isn't blocked, and check foreign-transaction fees with your bank.

Q: Do they accept my contactless card or phone?

Often yes in cities, but not everywhere. Have a physical card and some cash as fallback.

Q: How does paying work?

At many shops there's a small tray for handing over cash rather than passing it hand-to-hand. Prices usually include tax at the register; confirm whether tax is added.

Q: What about tax-free shopping?

Some stores offer tax-free purchases for tourists above a minimum spend, with your passport. Rules vary by shop — ask in-store and check current conditions.

3. Tipping & Etiquette

Q: Do I tip?

No. Tipping is not customary and can cause confusion. Good service is standard and already included. A sincere "thank you" is the right gesture.

Q: General etiquette basics:

- Be quiet and considerate in public and on transit.
- Remove shoes where indicated (homes, some restaurants, traditional spaces) — look for a step or shoe shelf.
- Don't walk while eating in many places; eat near where you bought the food.
- Carry a small bag for your trash — public bins are scarce. Sort recycling where bins exist.
- Queue neatly and wait your turn.
- Bowing is common; a small nod is a friendly default for visitors.

Q: Onsen / public bath basics?

Wash thoroughly before entering the shared bath. The bath is for soaking, not washing. Check policies on tattoos in advance, as they vary by facility.

Q: Eating etiquette?

Don't stick chopsticks upright in rice or pass food chopstick-to-chopstick. Slurping noodles is fine and even welcomed.

4. Staying Connected (eSIM, SIM, Pocket WiFi)

Q: How do I get mobile data?

Common options:

- eSIM — buy and install before you arrive if your phone supports it; activates on landing. Convenient and contactless.

- Physical travel SIM — a data SIM you swap in; available to order ahead or buy on arrival.
- Pocket WiFi — a rented portable router that connects multiple devices; good for groups or shared use.

Compare data limits, validity, and coverage, and check the latest plans before buying.

Q: Is there free WiFi?

Available in many stations, convenience stores, cafes, and hotels, but coverage is patchy on the move. Don't rely on it for navigation — your own data is more dependable.

Q: Will my phone work?

Check that your phone is unlocked and supports the local bands. Confirm with your carrier and device specs.

Q: Handy apps to set up before you go:

- Offline maps / navigation
- A translation app (camera translation is very handy)
- Your transit / IC card in a mobile wallet if supported
- Your accommodation and booking confirmations saved offline

5. When Things Go Wrong

Q: I'm lost or confused at a station.

Look for station staff near the gates — many can help with basic English or by pointing at signage. Major-line signage usually includes English and station numbers.

Q: Emergencies?

- Police emergency and fire/ambulance have separate national numbers — write them down before you travel and confirm the current numbers for Japan.
- For non-emergencies, ask hotel/accommodation staff first; they can often call on your behalf.
- Keep your country's embassy/consulate contact saved.

Q: Medical needs?

Carry any prescription meds with documentation, and check in advance whether any of your medications are restricted. Pharmacies and clinics are widely available; travel insurance is strongly recommended.

Q: I lost something.

Lost-and-found is taken seriously. Report it to staff at the station, shop, or venue where you think you lost it; items are frequently recovered.

Q: Language barrier?

A translation app plus a few polite phrases goes a long way. Many menus have pictures, and pointing is perfectly acceptable.

6. Quick Checklists

Before you fly:

- ☒ Passport valid, copies saved offline
- ☒ Travel insurance arranged
- ☒ Bank notified; foreign-transaction fees checked
- ☒ eSIM/SIM/pocket WiFi sorted
- ☒ Offline maps & translation app installed
- ☒ Bookings & addresses saved offline
- ☒ Power adapter packed

Daily carry:

- ☒ IC card (or mobile transit set up)
- ☒ Some cash + a card
- ☒ Phone, charger, battery pack
- ☒ Small trash bag
- ☒ Comfortable shoes

7. A Few Useful Phrases

English	Romanized Japanese
Hello	Konnichiwa
Thank you	Arigatou gozaimasu
Excuse me / sorry	Sumimasen
Yes / No	Hai / Iie
How much is it?	Ikura desu ka?
Where is the station?	Eki wa doko desu ka?
English menu, please?	Eigo no menyu wa arimasu ka?
I don't eat ____ (allergy)	____ ga taberaremasen
Help!	Tasukete!
Cash / card	Genkin / Kaado

Final Notes

Take it slow, stay considerate, and don't over-pack your days. Confirm hours, fares, and services from official sources as you go — details change, and a quick check saves headaches.